SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #10 · CHRIST

“Jesus died for other people’s sins, but not ones as bad as mine.”

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Where it often comes from

Deep shame about something in your past. Being told by a parent or church that certain sins put you beyond help. Comparing your worst moments with other people’s best. Having confessed many times without feeling forgiven. A sensitive conscience, or intrusive thoughts that seem to prove you are especially bad.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus came into the world to save sinners, and Paul, who once persecuted Christians, called himself the worst of them. Christ’s blood cleanses from *all* sin. God promises to make scarlet sins white as snow and to remove them as far as the east is from the west. Where sin is great, grace is greater. Your sin is not bigger than the cross.

> *“But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin”* **(1 John 1:7)**.

Also see

> “This is a trustworthy saying, worthy of full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the worst” **(1 Timothy 1:15)**.

> “‘Come now, let us reason together,’ says the LORD. ‘Though your sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow; though they are as red as crimson, they will become like wool.’” **(Isaiah 1:18)**.

> “As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us” **(Psalm 103:12)**.

> “When you were dead in your trespasses and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our trespasses, having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees that stood against us. He took it away, nailing it to the cross!” **(Colossians 2:13–14)**.

Common self-statements

- What I did is too terrible to forgive.
- Grace is for other people, not me.
- If people knew, they’d agree I’m beyond saving.
- I’ve sinned too many times for God to keep forgiving.
- God forgives small sins, but mine are different.
- I don’t deserve to be forgiven.

Common logical errors

- **Magnification:** Making your sin look bigger than Christ’s sacrifice.
- **Personalization:** Believing that God’s promises apply to everyone except you.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I still feel guilty, so I must not be forgiven.”

- **Labeling:** Calling yourself “unforgivable” instead of “a sinner Jesus came to save.”
- **Disqualifying the positive:** Dismissing every verse about forgiveness as not meant for you.

Challenging questions

- Does 1 John 1:7 say Jesus cleanses from some sin, or from all sin?
- Is my sin bigger than the cross of Christ?
- Paul called himself the worst of sinners. Did God refuse to forgive him?
- Am I making my feelings a higher authority than God’s Word?
- If I were God, would I want my forgiveness to have a limit?
- Is refusing forgiveness a kind of pride, as if my sin is too special for grace?
- Who first told me I was beyond forgiveness?

Truth summary

> Jesus died for all my sins, including the ones I am most ashamed of. His blood cleanses me from all sin. My worst moments are not stronger than His grace. When I confess, He forgives, and He removes my sins as far as the east is from the west. I am forgiven because of what He did, not because I feel worthy.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Christ, Sacrifice of
- Guilt/Shame
- Grace
- Mercy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Jesus died for other people's sins, but not ones as bad as mine"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Jesus died for other people's sins, but not ones as bad as mine." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Does Jesus cleanse from some sin, or all sin?
- ☐ Is my sin bigger than the cross?
- ☐ If God forgave Paul, why not me?
- ☐ Am I trusting my feelings over God's Word?
- ☐ Is my sin really too special for grace?
- ☐ Who first told me I was beyond forgiveness?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus' blood cleanses me from all sin.
- ☐ My sin is not bigger than the cross.
- ☐ Christ came to save sinners like me.
- ☐ Where my sin increased, grace increased all the more.
- ☐ God has removed my sins as far as the east is from the west.
- ☐ I am forgiven because of Jesus, not because of my feelings.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **1 John 1:7**
  "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin."
- [ ] **1 Timothy 1:15**
  "This is a trustworthy saying, worthy of full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the worst."
- [ ] **Isaiah 1:18**
  "'Come now, let us reason together,' says the LORD. 'Though your sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow; though they are as red as crimson, they will become like wool.'"
- [ ] **Psalm 103:12**
  "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us."
- [ ] **Colossians 2:13–14**
  "When you were dead in your trespasses and in the uncircumcision of your sinful nature, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our trespasses, having canceled the debt ascribed to us in the decrees that stood against us. He took it away, nailing it to the cross!"

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Forgiveness log:** Each time the old shame returns, write: "That debt was nailed to the cross," and the date.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Isaiah 1:18 becomes: "'Come now, let us reason together,' says the LORD. 'Though **Sarah's** sins are like scarlet, they will be as white as snow; though they are as red as crimson, they will become like wool.'"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write the sin you are most ashamed of on a slip of paper,** read Colossians 2:13–14 over it, then tear it up and throw it away.
- ☐ **Confess once and receive it:** pray 1 John 1:9, then thank God instead of confessing the same sin again.
- ☐ **Read the story of the sinful woman in Luke 7:36–50,** and notice how Jesus treats her.
- ☐ **Talk with a pastor or trusted Christian friend** about what forgiveness means, and write down what you learn.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Jesus died for other people's sins, but not ones as bad as mine": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One reminder that I'm forgiven
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Jesus died for other people's sins, but not ones as bad as mine.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, thank You that You came to save sinners, and that Your blood cleanses me from all sin. Help me reject the lie that my sins are too great for You. When shame returns, remind me that my debt was nailed to the cross. Teach me to receive Your forgiveness and to live in the freedom You paid for. In Your name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.